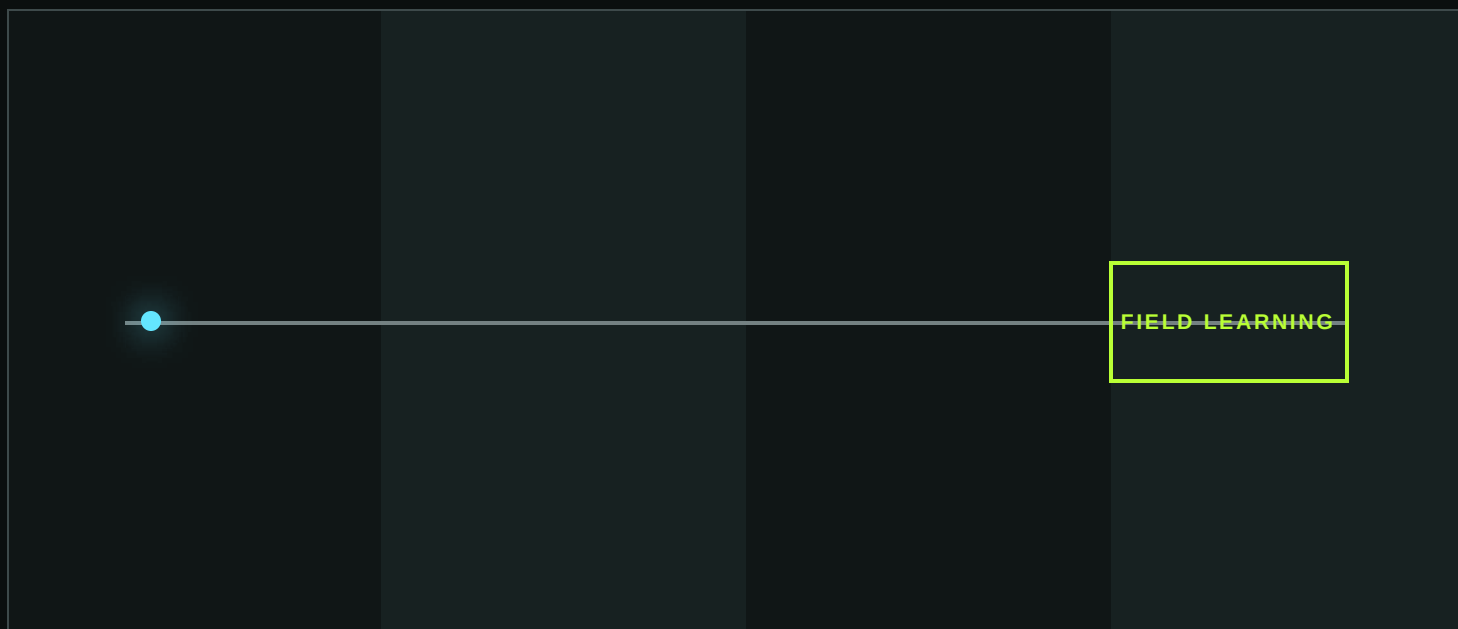




INDEPENDENT CANDIDATE ENTRY
PLAN

120 days to make portfolio decisions earlier, clearer, and more useful.

Product Associate Director (Group Product Manager)
Russell Dudek



Entry principle: tactical empathy before prescription. Read the mission and the existing product system before changing cadence, artifacts, or authority.

Candidate vision: <https://russelldudek.github.io/TwoSix/>

DAYS 1-30

Read the mission and map the product system.

Understand how mission demand, product evidence, technical constraints, acquisition realities, and team craft currently meet before changing the operating rhythm.

OPERATING QUESTION

Where do product decisions become slow, ambiguous, expensive, or disconnected from the people doing the actual work?

Listening map

- Product and UX leaders: portfolio intent, team autonomy, coaching needs, and decision friction.
- Engineering, AI/ML, architecture, security, test, and quality: dependencies, evidence thresholds, integration burden, and release constraints.
- Growth, capture, sales, contracts, and acquisition: buyer language, commitments, competitive differentiation, funding, and timing.
- Deployment, support, program, mission, and partners: operator friction, recurring field work, trust signals, and learning that is not returning to the roadmap.

Discovery and decision rights

- Which choices belong to product teams, portfolio leadership, platform owners, or executive sponsors?
- What evidence is sufficient to accelerate, scale, productize, integrate, prove, hold, or stop?
- How do open, restricted, and classified environments change discovery, testing, feedback, and support?
- Where do roadmap language, growth positioning, engineering dependencies, support burden, and acquisition path diverge?

Four diagnostic workstreams

READ BEFORE REDESIGN

WORKSTREAM	WHAT I WOULD EXAMINE	DECISION IT SHOULD IMPROVE
Portfolio truth	Roadmaps, backlogs, release decisions, product narratives, and investment questions.	Which bets need evidence, capacity, alignment, or a clearer stop condition.
Mission and user access	Discovery channels, feedback quality, environment constraints, and proxy-user risk.	How much confidence to place in current assumptions.
Field and integration signals	Support themes, deployment patterns, interfaces, recurring work, and handoffs.	What remains local, becomes reusable, or moves toward productization.
Team craft	Problem framing, evidence use, decision writing, discovery, and UX partnership.	Where coaching can improve product judgment fastest.

Day 30 outputs

WORKING RECORDS

Portfolio decision map: named authority for investment, release, integration, evidence, escalation, and stop decisions.

Mission/user access map: how teams reach users and validate work across constrained environments.

Signal inventory: field, support, deployment, evaluation, growth, and acquisition inputs available for roadmap learning.

PM/UX coaching baseline: strengths to preserve, friction to remove, and the first coaching cadence to test.

DAY 30 CHECKPOINT

Leadership can see where consequential product decisions are made, what evidence they use, where ownership is unclear, and which three decision problems deserve a bounded proof cycle.

DAYS 31-60

Frame a minimal shared portfolio contract.

Co-create enough common structure to improve cross-product decisions without flattening product-team judgment or importing process for process's sake.

OPERATING QUESTION

What is the smallest shared decision contract that makes mission value, human authority, proof, integration, acquisition, and learning visible?

Mission Window Contract

USE EXISTING LANGUAGE WHEREVER POSSIBLE

Mission outcome

User problem, consequence, and intended improvement.

Human authority

Retained decisions, review, escalation, and fallback.

Integration fit

Interfaces, platforms, data, security, and deployment.

Evidence threshold

User, technical, evaluation, trust, and operating proof.

Acquisition path

Buyer, procurement route, timing, and commitment risk.

Learning return

How field evidence changes roadmap or portfolio.

Three portfolio hypotheses

- 1 Recurring support, deployment, or integration work may reveal reusable capability not yet visible as an investment choice.
- 2 Roadmap conflict may resolve earlier when evidence threshold, acquisition path, and dependency owner are explicit before capacity is committed.
- 3 AI-assisted product tradecraft may reduce synthesis burden when source traceability, human review, evaluation, and accountability remain explicit.

Decision rights

- **Product teams:** discovery, problem framing, backlog, experience, release readiness, and local learning.
- **Portfolio leadership:** investment, capacity, cross-product leverage, sequencing, productization, and stop decisions.
- **Partners:** security, contracts, growth, deployment, quality, architecture, and mission-specific constraints.

Each layer shares named evidence, dependencies, owners, and escalation conditions.

AI-assisted product tradecraft pilots

BOUNDED AND REVIEWED

SYNTHESIS

Discovery evidence

Summarize interviews and support themes with source links and human validation.

QUALITY

Requirement critique

Expose ambiguity, missing acceptance evidence, authority boundaries, and dependencies.

FLOW

Backlog and test support

Draft decomposition, test ideas, release questions, and decision records without delegating judgment.

DAY 60 CHECKPOINT

Three portfolio hypotheses have named owners, baseline evidence, review dates, and proof or stop conditions. A coaching cadence and bounded AI pilots are operating with visible human responsibility.

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DAYS 61-90

Prove the mechanism in live product work.

Use real decisions to test whether the shared contract improves judgment, exposes constraints earlier, and produces clearer commitments.

OPERATING QUESTION

Can a compact review improve an actual decision without creating a parallel bureaucracy or replacing product judgment with a score?

First live Mission Window Reviews

ILLUSTRATIVE SET; FINAL SELECTION FOLLOWS DISCOVERY

REVIEW 01 Agentic orchestration Clarify outcome, tool and data authority, evaluation burden, platform dependencies, deployment posture, and next evidence.	REVIEW 02 Information operations Connect mission effect, analyst trust, provenance, integration, user workflow, buyer language, and repeatable behavior.	REVIEW 03 Sensor / CBRNE Make field evidence, consequence, assurance, support burden, integration repeatability, and productization choice explicit.
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Review mechanics

- One concise pre-read: decision, mission outcome, evidence, dependencies, authority, acquisition path, and unresolved questions.
- A time-bounded working review focused on the decision, not status presentation.
- One explicit disposition: accelerate, scale, productize, integrate, prove, hold, stop, or return for named evidence.
- A decision record with owners, commitments, next evidence, escalation, and learning return.

Evidence standards

- **User:** workflow, consequence, trust, and adoption.
- **Technical:** architecture, data, interfaces, security, evaluation, quality, and failure behavior.
- **Authority and operations:** review, override, fallback, deployment, support, partner, and sustainment burden.
- **Commercial and learning:** buyer, acquisition route, commitment, timing, and evidence that changes the roadmap.

Operating tensions to resolve

NAMED OWNERS AND EVIDENCE

TENSION	WORKING RESOLUTION	PROOF OUTPUT
Capacity conflict	Compare mission consequence, evidence threshold, acquisition timing, and opportunity cost.	Sequencing decision with owner and revisit condition.
Platform vs. product	Separate reusable capability from product-specific operator work and integration.	Boundary decision with ownership, support, reuse, and funding path.
Speed vs. assurance	Match evaluation, human authority, security, and fallback to consequence.	Release or proof posture with explicit assurance burden.

Coaching through the work

COACHING CADENCE

Before	PM and UX lead sharpen the problem, evidence, decision request, and user consequence.	Frame
During	They lead; I help expose assumptions, tradeoffs, and missing ownership.	Judge
After	We inspect decision quality, stakeholder clarity, and what should become reusable.	Learn

DAY 90 CHECKPOINT

Three consequential decisions have explicit evidence standards, owners, commitments, and learning return. The cycle has resolved a capacity conflict and a platform/product boundary—or exposed the exact evidence needed.

DAYS 91-120

Institutionalize learning and set the next horizon.

Keep only the mechanisms that improve decisions, return evidence to the portfolio, strengthen product leadership, and expose recurring work as an investment choice.

OPERATING QUESTION

What must become routine so product advantage compounds after the first proof cycle instead of depending on one leader or one review?

Operating cadence to institutionalize		MINIMUM EFFECTIVE SYSTEM
Monthly	Evidence review for active hypotheses, unresolved dependencies, field/support signals, and upcoming decisions.	Decision readiness
Quarterly	Portfolio review for investment, capacity, leverage, productization, integration, proof, hold, and stop decisions.	Portfolio coherence
Biweekly	PM/UX coaching using live discovery, decision writing, evidence, stakeholder, and roadmap work.	Team craft
Continuous	Field, support, deployment, evaluation, growth, and acquisition learning returned to roadmaps.	Learning return

Executive roadmap narrative

- Mission outcome, user consequence, and evidence supporting each major bet.
- Human authority, assurance, integration, and deployment constraints.
- Acquisition path, buyer, timing, competitive story, dependencies, and capacity.
- Proof, stop, or revisit condition that protects the portfolio.

Product economics and recurring work

- Expose recurring support, deployment, configuration, integration, training, and evaluation work.
- Separate mission-specific work from patterns that justify reuse, platform investment, or productization.
- Make ownership, funding, sustainment, and customer promise explicit before recurring work becomes hidden product debt.
- Connect growth opportunity to total delivery burden and support reality.

120-day success evidence

BASELINES ESTABLISHED FIRST

DIMENSION	WHAT SHOULD BE VISIBLY DIFFERENT
Decision clarity	Decision rights are explicit; conflicts have owners, next evidence, and escalation conditions.
Roadmap quality	Major bets show mission outcome, authority, evidence threshold, acquisition path, integration burden, dependencies, and learning return.
Team craft	PM and UX leaders demonstrate stronger problem framing, evidence use, decision writing, and cross-functional communication.
Product economics	Recurring work is visible and classified for local delivery, reuse, platform investment, or productization.
AI and learning speed	Selected practices are faster without hiding accountability, and field evidence has changed at least one product or investment decision.

Next-quarter decisions

FORWARD AGENDA

- Which bets accelerate, scale, productize, integrate, prove, hold, or stop.
 - Which cross-product capabilities deserve platform ownership and investment.
 - Which evidence gaps require user access, technical proof, acquisition discovery, or operating validation.
- Which two PM/UX craft priorities anchor the next coaching cycle.
 - Which two AI-assisted product tradecraft experiments expand, change, or retire.
 - Which artifacts or meetings disappear because they do not improve actual decisions.

Targets should be set after baselines are established. This plan avoids fabricated percentages, maturity scores, or assumptions about undisclosed internal performance.